

Topic 5.1 - The conditions you will actually teach in

A real classroom situation

Miss Shahnaz teaches Class 4 in a government primary school outside Nawabshah. Her timetable says she teaches six periods a day.

Last Tuesday she taught eight, because a colleague was absent and there is no cover arrangement. She marked forty-three notebooks. She completed a district enrolment return that took ninety minutes because the format changed this year. She spoke to two parents at the gate about a child who has stopped attending. She prepared nothing, because there was no time left, and taught Wednesday's lesson from memory.

None of this is unusual, and none of it appears in any account of what she does. Ask a member of the public what a primary teacher's job is and you will be told: six periods a day, and long holidays.

Explanation

Workload, and what actually consumes a teacher's week

The figure above itemises the week. The pattern it shows matters more than the individual rows: **the parts of the job that are invisible from outside are the parts that expand.**

Timetabled teaching is fixed and visible. Everything else, the marking, the returns, the cover, the parent contact, the duties assigned at short notice, is elastic, invisible, and lands on whoever will absorb it. A conscientious teacher absorbs more of it than a disengaged one, which produces the first hard fact of

this unit: **under these conditions the workload falls hardest on the teachers who care most.**

Three consequences follow.

Preparation is the first casualty. It is the only substantial part of the job with no external deadline. Nobody notices on Tuesday that Wednesday's lesson was not prepared, and by the time anyone notices the pattern it has become normal.

The official workload and the actual workload diverge, and only the official one is used in planning, staffing and public discussion. Arguments about teacher workload frequently fail because the two sides are counting different things.

The elasticity is invisible until it fails. A school running on teachers absorbing extra duties looks fine right up until the moment a teacher stops absorbing them.

Stress and burnout, and how the two differ

Burnout is not a strong word for stress, and treating the two as the same thing is the most consequential misconception in this topic.

Stress is the response to demands that exceed resources in the moment. It is normal, it is episodic, and it resolves when the demand passes or the resources arrive. The week before examinations is stressful, and the week after is not.

Burnout is what chronic, unresolved demand produces over time. Maslach and Leiter (2016) describe it as having three dimensions: **exhaustion**, the depletion of energy; **cynicism** or depersonalisation, a growing distance from the work and from the people in it; and a reduced sense of **personal accomplishment** or efficacy, the feeling that nothing you do makes a difference.

Note the scope of that source honestly: Maslach and Leiter review burnout across human-service occupations, health care in particular, and their paper is not about teachers. The construct is theirs; the application to a classroom is an extension.

For teachers specifically, Skaalvik and Skaalvik (2020) followed 262 Norwegian high-school teachers across a school year, measuring job demands and job

resources at one point and burnout, job satisfaction and intention to leave teaching later. The demands they measured were **time pressure**, **low student motivation** and a **dissonant value context**, meaning a workplace whose values conflict with the teacher's own. The resources were **autonomy** and **supervisory support**.

That study was done in Norway, in high schools, with teachers whose conditions differ from Miss Shahnaz's in almost every material respect. What travels is not the numbers but the shape of the model: burnout is produced by the relationship between demands and resources, not by demands alone. This matters practically, because it means there are two levers, and the second one is usually the neglected one.

The dimensions also explain something trainees find puzzling. A burnt-out teacher is often not the one who looks overwhelmed. Exhaustion is visible; cynicism looks like competence, because the teacher has stopped investing and therefore stopped being visibly distressed. The colleague who says "do not waste your time on that class, they will not pass anyway" is not giving you practical advice. They are describing the second dimension.

The figure above adds the practical part. Because burnout comes from the **balance**, it can be interrupted by removing a demand or by adding a resource, and the second is often available when the first is not. Miss Shahnaz cannot stop the enrolment return. She might be able to secure a cover arrangement, or an hour of protected preparation time, or a colleague who takes half the marking in exchange for half of hers.

Lack of support and resources

The resource side of that balance is where Pakistani conditions bite hardest, and it is worth being concrete rather than general. Missing resources in a typical government school include:

- **Physical:** textbooks arriving late or not at all, no blackboard space, no electricity in summer, a room built for thirty holding sixty.
- **Human:** no teaching assistant, no subject specialist to ask, no cover when a colleague is absent.

- **Instructional:** no library, no manipulatives, one copy of the teacher's guide for the school.
- **Structural:** no protected preparation time, no functioning referral route for a struggling pupil.

The last two categories are the ones trainees underestimate. A missing blackboard is obvious and gets discussed. The absence of anyone to ask about a pupil who cannot decode at Class 4 is not discussed, and it is the more damaging gap, because it converts a solvable problem into a permanent one.

A note on what this unit will not do. It will not tell you that a resourceful teacher can substitute for these things. Some can be worked around, and Topic 5.4 deals with that honestly. Others cannot, and pretending otherwise puts the responsibility for a system's failure onto the individual standing in front of the class.

The multilingual classroom

Many Pakistani classrooms contain pupils whose home language is not the language of instruction, and often several home languages at once: Sindhi, Siraiki, Balochi, Pashto, Urdu, and English arriving as a third or fourth.

The instructional difficulty is real. A pupil processing a lesson in their second or third language carries a cognitive load their classmates do not, and that load shows up as slowness or inattention that is easily misread as low ability. Unit 3's warning about mistaking a condition for a trait applies directly.

The misconception to defeat here is that **the home language is the problem and should be excluded**. Treating a child's home language as an obstacle teaches them that part of who they are does not belong at school, and it removes the one resource they have for understanding a difficult idea. The workable practices are the opposite: let pupils discuss a concept in the language they think in before they write it in the language of instruction; take an answer in whatever language it arrives in when the thinking behind it is sound, then supply the words for it in the language of instruction; pair pupils who share a home language deliberately.

This unit cites no research for those practices, because none was verified while it was written. They are offered as reasoned practice consistent with the general

point about cognitive load, not as findings. Treat them as worth trying and worth evaluating with the Topic 3.5 researcher method.

The multi-grade classroom

A multi-grade classroom is one in which a single teacher is responsible for pupils of two or more grade levels at the same time, in the same room. It arises wherever enrolment is too small or teachers too few for one class per grade, which in Pakistan means a large share of rural primary schools.

Little (2001) argued that multigrade teaching deserved an international research and policy agenda of its own, which tells you something about its status: it is extremely common and has been treated as an aberration rather than as a normal condition requiring its own preparation.

The difficulties are specific and do not reduce to "more work":

- Two or more curricula must be planned for the same period.
- Direct instruction can only be given to one group at a time, so the others must be doing something worthwhile unsupervised.
- Assessment multiplies, and so does record-keeping.
- Most teacher preparation, including most of this course, implicitly assumes one grade.

Naparan and Alinsug (2021) interviewed ten multigrade teachers in Zamboanga del Sur in the Philippines about what they actually do, and found strategies clustering around classroom management, collaborative learning, differentiated instruction, connecting teaching to real-life situations, and integrating technology. That is ten teachers in one district of one country, so treat it as an existence proof rather than a prescription: these are things multigrade teachers find workable, not a validated method.

The honest summary is that multi-grade teaching is a distinct skill, it is widely required, and it is barely taught. If you are posted to such a school, you will be learning it on the job, and knowing that in advance is itself useful.

Activity: Itemise the week

Work in groups of three or four.

Between you, reconstruct one week of a government primary teacher in as much detail as you can: every activity, a rough time for each, and two marks against it - is it visible to someone outside the school, and is it counted in the official workload?

Then answer two questions as a group. First, which activities would a teacher drop first under pressure, and what is the consequence? Second, which single added resource would relieve the most pressure, and is it one a school could actually supply?

Allow 30 minutes. If anyone in the group has taught, build the week from their experience rather than from imagination.

Check your understanding

1. Distinguish stress from burnout, and name the three dimensions of burnout. *(Understand)*
2. Explain why, under the conditions described, workload falls hardest on the most conscientious teachers. *(Understand)*
3. Explain why preparation is the first thing to be dropped, and what makes that hard to notice. *(Apply)*
4. A colleague advises you not to waste effort on a weak class. Identify what this most likely indicates, using the burnout dimensions. *(Apply)*
5. Explain why excluding a pupil's home language is both a pedagogical and an ethical mistake. *(Analyze)*
6. Name three specific difficulties of multi-grade teaching that do not reduce to "more work". *(Remember)*

Summary

A teacher's week is dominated by parts of the job that are invisible from outside and therefore elastic: marking, returns, cover, parent contact, assigned duties. The elastic parts land on whoever absorbs them, so workload falls hardest on the most conscientious, preparation is dropped first because it alone has no

external deadline, and official workload diverges from actual workload in a way that defeats most arguments about it.

Stress is episodic and resolves; burnout is what chronic unresolved demand produces, and it has three dimensions: exhaustion, cynicism or distancing, and a reduced sense of accomplishment. It comes from the relationship between demands and resources, which means adding a resource is a lever when removing a demand is not. Cynicism is the dimension that looks like competence.

Missing resources in Pakistani government schools are physical, human, instructional and structural, and the last two are the most underestimated. Multilingual classrooms impose a real cognitive load that is easily misread as low ability, and excluding the home language removes the pupil's best resource. Multi-grade teaching is a distinct, widely required and barely taught skill.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can distinguish stress from burnout and name burnout's three dimensions.
- ☐ I can explain the demands-and-resources relationship and identify both levers.
- ☐ I can recognise cynicism as a burnout dimension rather than as realism.
- ☐ I can name the four categories of missing resource and say which are underestimated.
- ☐ I can describe the specific demands of multilingual and multi-grade classrooms without reducing either to "more work".
- ☐ I can state where this topic's claims come from, and which have no research behind them.

Try this at your practicum school

For one full day, shadow a teacher and record every activity with a time, including the short ones: signing a register, answering a parent at the gate, covering five minutes of another class.

Total the time that appears on the timetable and the time that does not.

Write half a page on the ratio you found and on which of the uncounted activities would be the first to be dropped. Show the teacher your total if they want to see it; most are surprised by it, because the uncounted work is invisible to the person doing it as well.

Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words.

Miss Shahnaz's Tuesday is described at the top of this topic. Analyse it using the demands-and-resources idea, and propose the two interventions you judge most likely to help.

Your answer must distinguish demands from resources, identify which of her demands could realistically be removed and which could not, and defend your two interventions against the objection that they require someone else to act. Say explicitly which parts of your analysis rest on research and which are reasoned from the conditions described.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Use of the model (Apply)	Separates demands from resources accurately and applies both to the specific Tuesday described
Realism about constraints	Distinguishes what a teacher, a head, and a district can each change
Defence of the interventions (Analyze)	Engages with the objection that the proposals depend on others, and says what remains possible if nobody else acts
Evidence honesty	States which claims rest on the cited studies and which are reasoned, including the studies' scope

Further reading

- Maslach, C., & Leiter, M. P. (2016). Understanding the burnout experience: Recent research and its implications for psychiatry. *World Psychiatry*, 15(2), 103-111. <https://doi.org/10.1002/wps.20311> Burnout across human-service occupations; not a study of teachers.
- Skaalvik, E. M., & Skaalvik, S. (2020). Teacher burnout: Relations between dimensions of burnout, perceived school context, job satisfaction and motivation for teaching. A longitudinal study. *Teachers and Teaching*, 26(7-8), 602-616. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13540602.2021.1913404> 262 Norwegian high-school teachers.
- Little, A. W. (2001). Multigrade teaching: Towards an international research and policy agenda. *International Journal of Educational Development*, 21(6), 481-497. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0738-0593\(01\)00011-6](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0738-0593(01)00011-6)
- Naparan, G. B., & Alinsug, V. G. (2021). Classroom strategies of multigrade teachers. *Social Sciences & Humanities Open*, 3(1), 100109. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ssaho.2021.100109> Ten teachers in one Philippine district.

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